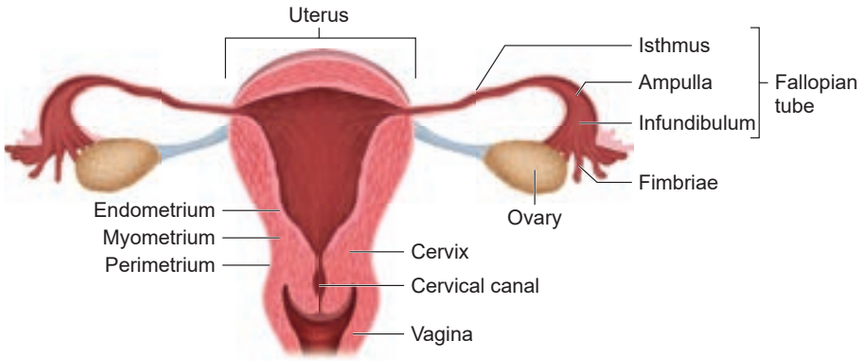


Fig. 2.3 (b) Diagrammatic view of female reproductive system

which help in collection of the ovum after ovulation. The infundibulum leads to a wider central portion called **ampulla**. The last part of the oviduct is the isthmus which is short and thick walled connecting the ampulla and infundibulum to the uterus.

The uterus or womb is a hollow, thick-walled, muscular, highly vascular and inverted pear shaped structure lying in the pelvic cavity between the urinary bladder and rectum. The major portion of the uterus is the body and the rounded region superior to it, is the **fundus**. The uterus opens into the vagina through a narrow **cervix**. The cavity of the cervix called the cervical canal communicates with the vagina through the external orifice and with the uterus through the internal orifice. The cervical canal along with vagina forms the birth canal.

The wall of the uterus has three layers of tissues. The outermost thin membranous serous layer called the **perimetrium**, the middle thick muscular layer called **myometrium** and the inner glandular layer called **endometrium**. The endometrium undergoes cyclic changes during the menstrual cycle while myometrium exhibits strong contractions during parturition.

Vagina is a large fibromuscular tube that extends from the cervix to the exterior. It is the female organ of copulation. The female reproductive structures that lie external to the vagina are called as the external genitalia or vulva comprising of **labia majora, labia minora, hymen and clitoris**.

The **Bartholin's glands** (also called greater vestibular glands) are located posterior to the left and right of the opening of the vagina. They secrete mucus to lubricate the vagina and are homologous to the bulbourethral glands of the male. The **Skene's glands** are located on the anterior wall of the vagina and around the lower end of the urethra. They secrete a lubricating fluid and are homologous to the prostate gland of the males.

The external opening of the vagina is partially closed by a thin ring of tissue called the hymen. The hymen is often torn during the first coitus (physical union). However in some women it remains intact. It can be stretched or torn due to a sudden fall or jolt and also during strenuous physical activities such as cycling, horseback riding, etc., and therefore cannot be considered as an indicator of a woman's virginity.

The **mammary glands** are modified sweat glands present in both sexes. It is rudimentary in the males and functional in the females. A pair of mammary glands is located in the thoracic region. It contains glandular tissue and variable quantities of fat with a median nipple surrounded by a pigmented area called the **areola**. Several sebaceous glands called the areolar glands are found on the surface and they reduce cracking of the skin of the nipple. Internally each mammary gland consists of 2-25 lobes, separated by fat and connective tissues **(Fig. 2.4).** Each lobe is made up of lobules which contain **acini or alveoli** lined by epithelial cells. Cells of the alveoli secrete milk. The alveoli open into **mammary tubules**. The tubules of each lobe join to form

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